

Understanding Generative AI in Creative Practice

I've taken a course on generative AI before, and I also use AI tools fairly often at my job, so my understanding of it comes less from theory and more from actually working with it. At its core, generative AI is a system trained on huge amounts of data, images, text, whatever the case may be, that learns patterns well enough to produce new content that fits those patterns. It's not "thinking" the way people do, but it's very good at picking up on style, structure, and repetition.

From my experience, I don't see generative AI as a threat to designers. It's more like a tool that speeds up the parts of the process that used to take the longest. It's great for quickly testing ideas, generating variations, and seeing options I wouldn't have thought of on my own, which is basically what happened while I was working on the three images for this assignment. I also got the chance to visit SAT (Société des Arts Technologiques) and see one of their locally-run AI models in action. That was interesting because it made me think about how differently AI can be built and used depending on who's running it and why. Not every model has to be a massive closed system.

The work that actually inspires me is "Hello Vincent," an application developed by the startup Jumbo Mana for Musée d'Orsay, connected to their Van Gogh exhibition. It lets visitors have a real conversation with an AI version of Van Gogh, trained on around 900 of his letters, while he "paints" Wheatfield with Crows in front of them. What I like about this project is how openly it's presented. It's clearly labeled as an AI experience, built with an actual art historian, and it's honest about being a tool for learning, not a replacement for the real paintings.

That honesty matters to me because AI art gets treated unfairly a lot of the time. In another class, we talked about an experiment where someone posted an actual, unaltered Van Gogh painting online but labeled it as AI generated, and people immediately started criticizing it, not because it looked bad, but purely because of the label. That stuck with me. A lot of the backlash against AI art isn't really about quality, it's about bias against the label itself. "Hello Vincent" feels like the opposite of that: it doesn't hide what it is, and it still finds a genuinely meaningful way to bring people closer to an artist's work.